UX Writing Project - Export Course Button for Canvas

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Executive Summary

This document includes the research and writing necessary to announce a new feature for the online learning platform Canvas. Professors use Canvas to administer their course, allowing them to structure their course, share readings, facilitate discussions, grade assignments, and send announcements. For most university students, Canvas is the primary if not the only way to access the modules, readings, and discussion posts that make up their course.

My research led me to propose a new feature for Canvas that allows students to export a course out of Canvas and onto their local computer or cloud storage in as few clicks as possible. This new feature addresses a pain-point shared by interviewees: they cannot review course content when they cannot access the internet or their Canvas accounts. Once exported, students without wifi can still access their readings, lectures, or discussion posts while they are travelling home for the holidays. Alumni can use this feature to review their course content long after graduating, without relying on their university to maintain their access to Canvas.

This document contains three sections: research summary, feature announcement, and microcopy that you would find in the feature. Each section also contains a design summary which grounds my content decisions in user research.

Research

Feature Design Process

[Link to Miro Board]

I iterated towards a solution using the five steps of design thinking: emphasize, define, ideate, prototype, and test. First, I created two personas and an empathy map based on my own experience and an interview with an alumni. Second, I synthesized these interviews into 5 pain points, which I then rephrased as “how might we” statements in order define the problem in a way that centers the user. Third, I brainstormed several solutions and prototyped a UX mockup for one of these solutions using Obsidian. Finally, I tested my prototype on classmates and collected their feedback with a survey.

Feature Design Summary:

The design process informed the feature and how I chose to break it down into smaller pieces of microcopy. The feature needs to be quick to use and allow students to easily access their course content. Currently, it would take too long to manually download each reading and module from a course on Canvas. An export course button leading to a form could export your entire course in a few as five clicks.

Canvas already has a lot of features cluttering its user interface. Without clear UX writing, the new feature will go undiscovered in the clutter. The placement, content, and word choice of the microcopy that makes up the new feature must therefore distinguish and explain the new feature. Users must also be pointed to the new feature with a properly motivating feature announcement.

Feature Announcement

Feature Announcement Summary

Purpose: *To inform users and alumni about Canvas' new "export course" feature, allowing users to export their course content out of Canvas and onto their local computer or cloud storage. To motivate users and alumni to use this feature.*
Audience: *Current university students and alumni.*
Design summary:

I tried to copy the four genre moves of a feature announcement: (1) introduce the new feature, (2) explain its key benefits, (3) show how it works, and (4) encourage users to try it immediately).

- When introducing the new feature, I studied the language of other feature announcements (Spotify, Ticketmaster, GoodReads). In the first couple of sentences of their feature announcements, the writers used the following pattern to rapidly summarize the new feature: The product owner V's goal is W, which is why we added X feature so that Y people can do Z activity. I copied this pattern for the first two sentences of my feature announcement.
- When explaining its benefits, I described both the feature's value (fast, more accessible courses), as well as some real-life use cases for users (student accessing courses offline, alumni accessing courses after graduating).
- When showing how the feature works, I described where to find UI elements in order to help situate readers. I also structured the explainer as a sequential list of steps.
- To encourage users to try it immediately, I ended by conveying the value of the tool as well as providing an example of a type of person who could benefit (hoping that the person reading is that type of person).
    - I addressed the reader as "you" in the final paragraph to prompt them to take action.

- In the feature announcement, I motivated users to try the new feature by saying that it gives them permanent ownership over their course content. The idea to motivate users with ownership came out of ideating and prototyping. While designing the feature, I discovered that if students could export their courses out of Canvas, they would then have ownership over the course files, and could store or access them whenever or however they wanted. From my interviews, students said that owning their course content would make it easier for them to access.

Feature Announcement

Canvas wants to give you the power to learn wherever and whenever you want, which is why we are introducing the course export feature. Students can use the course export feature to download their courses off Canvas and onto their local device or cloud storage account. The export feature allows you to quickly download all the readings, modules, discussions, and feedback in any course - past or present. Busy college students can export their courses and then access them offline, so they catch up on coursework while travelling home for the holidays.

You can export a course in as little as five clicks. The button for exporting a course can be found in the top-right of the "all courses" page, as well as in the top-right of any course's homepage. Once pressed, an export window will appear. Select the course content you would like to download, such as files, modules, or discussion posts. Then select the export destination. You can decide to download the course to your local device, or you can log into your cloud storage account and export it there. Finally, select whether you would like to compress the export into a zip file, reducing the file size at the cost of making it more difficult to open.

Once you are happy with your choices, hit the download button. The export window will show a progress bar for the download as well as a success or failure message once the download is complete. If the download fails, you can usually resolve the issue by referring to this table of error messages.

Canvas is committed to guaranteeing students long-term access to their educational content. Exporting your course content gives you ownership over it. Once exported, you can access it on whatever device you want without the need for a Canvas account.

Graduating soon? Travelling without wifi? Simply log onto Canvas, select a course, and use the export course button today to secure access to your course content far into the future.

Microcopy

Microcopy Summary

Purpose: *Microcopy are small components of written text and sometimes symbols that make up a user interface. This microcopy implements the new export course feature. Microcopy must explain what a feature does, how to use the feature, and provide feedback to user inputs. Microcopy must be clear, concise, and consistent with the feature.*
Audience: *Current university students and alumni.*
Design summary:
I chose to write microcopy that includes challenges commonly faced by UX professional writers:

- I wrote several pieces of microcopy for the export form. In doing so, I had to make sure that each piece of microcopy was cohesive with the entire form. For example, the success and error messages must reference the export destination selected by the user.
- To avoid lawsuits, a tool like this needs a legal summary explaining that it may be illegal for students to distribute course content without permission. The legal summary has to succinctly warn the reader, while trying not to come across as rude or overly restrictive.
- I wrote a two-sentence summary that appears when users hover over the export course button. If the feature is not well introduced, then it will get lost in the clutter of Canvas' UI.

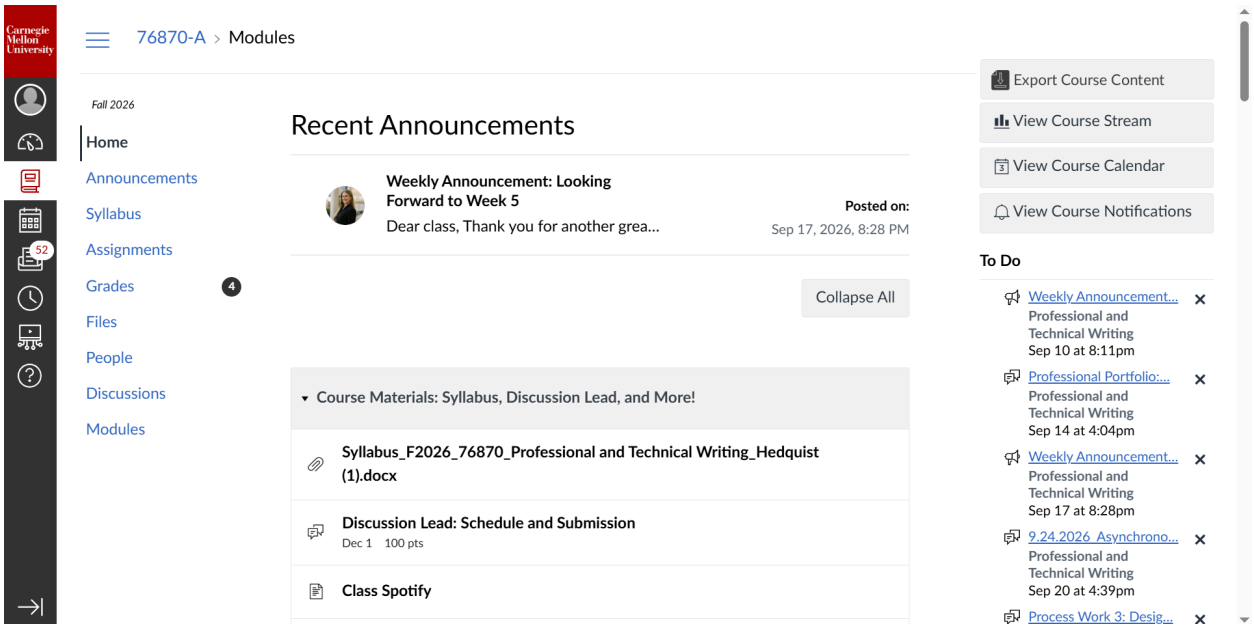
Microcopy Content

Microcopy as text

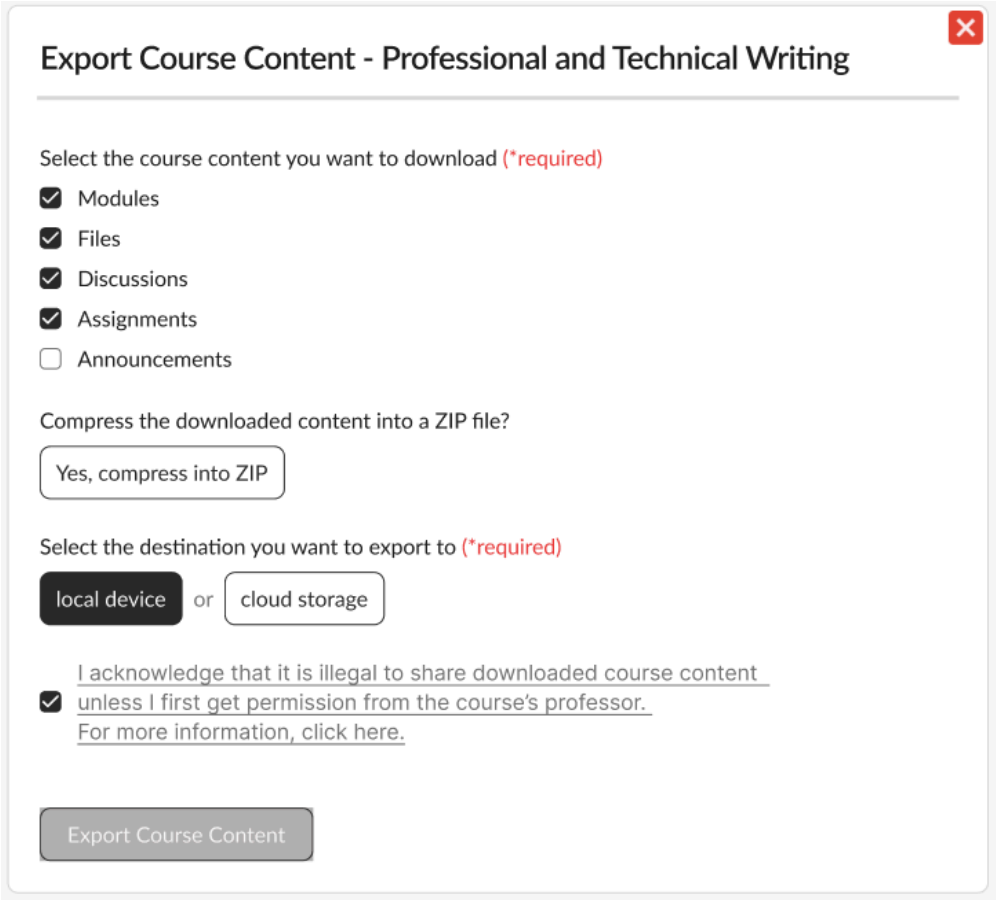
Purpose	*Text*
Tooltip that appears when the user hovers over the export course content button.	When you export a course out of Canvas, you can still access it while offline or after graduating. Select what you want to export, where you want to export it to, and whether to compress it into a zip file.
Form title	Export Course - "Course Name" (e.g. Professional and Technical Writing)
Form text - Question 1	Select the course content you want to download (*required)
Form text - Question 2	Select the destination you want to export to (*required)

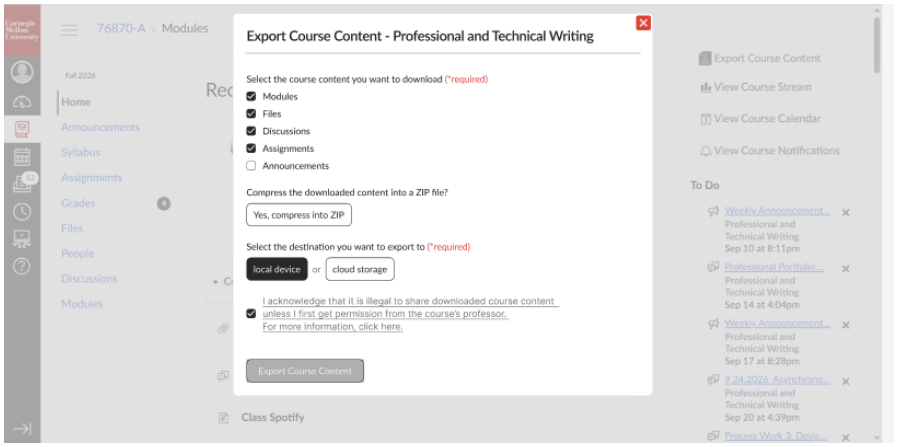
Success Message:	Successfully downloaded Y / X documents from “Course Name” to “destination (e.g. local device, asaalfeld@andrew.cmu.edu’s google drive)”
Red error message for when no course content boxes are checked from question	Please select the course content you want to download
Error Message:	Error: Failed to download documents from “Course Name” to “destination” because there is not enough storage free at “destination.” Please free up “X megabytes” of space on your local device then try again.
Legal summary	It is illegal to share the course content you download with others unless you first get permission from the course’s professor or university. For more information, click here.

Course Homepage with Export Course Button UI:

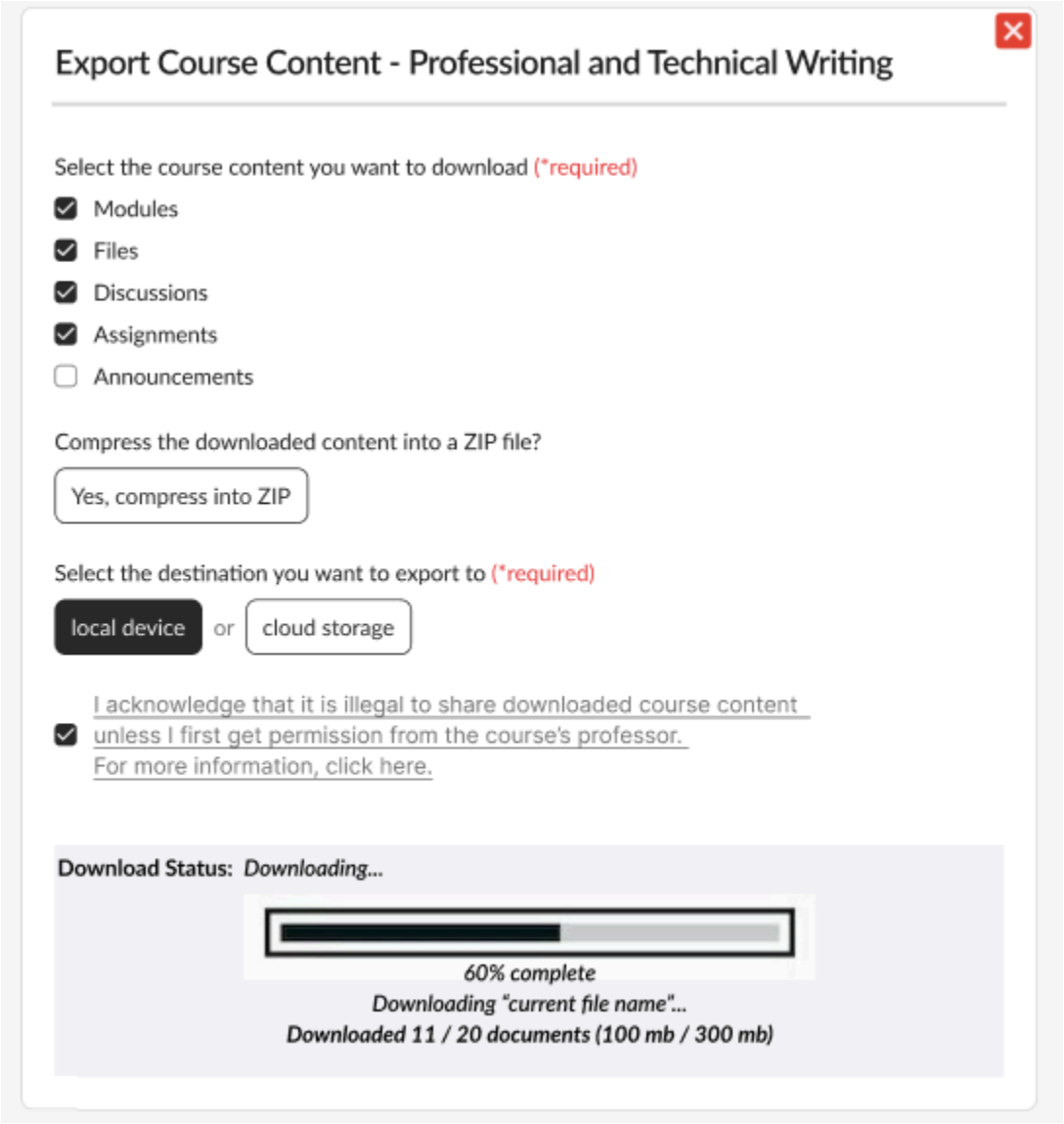


Export Course Content Form UI:





Export Course Content Form UI (Downloading):



Success popup:

